

British Museum - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Rosetta Stone: The Key That Unlocked Egypt

Head for the crowd — the most visited object in the museum is a broken grey slab, and it changed everything we know about ancient Egypt. For nearly one and a half thousand years, nobody on Earth could read Egyptian hieroglyphs. The knowledge had simply died out. Millions of symbols carved on temples and tombs: total mystery. Then, in 1799, French soldiers digging a fort in Egypt found this stone. It has the same announcement — a thank-you decree for a thirteen-year-old pharaoh from 196 BC — written three times: once in hieroglyphs, once in everyday Egyptian script, and once in ancient Greek. And scholars could still read Greek! It was like finding an answer key. Even so, cracking it took over twenty years. A French genius named Champollion finally did it in 1822 — when he realized it, he ran to his brother's office, shouted “I've got it!”, and fainted. Thanks to this stone, we can now read the ancient Egyptians' own words: their prayers, their homework, their jokes, even their complaints about bad beer. One more twist: the French found it, but the British took it when they defeated Napoleon in Egypt — look for the old painted labels on its sides. Both countries still feel strongly about that.

Tell Me More: Cracking the Code

How do you actually crack a dead language? Here's how Champollion did it. The Greek text mentioned the pharaoh Ptolemy, and on the stone, some hieroglyphs sit inside oval rings called cartouches — royal name-tags. So scholars guessed: those symbols must spell P-T-O-L-E-M-Y. Then another monument turned up with the name Cleopatra in both scripts. Ptolemy and Cleopatra share letters — P, T, O, L — and sure enough, the right symbols appeared in the right positions in both names. That proved hieroglyphs could spell SOUNDS, like our alphabet. But Champollion's genius move came with the name Ramesses: he recognized the sun symbol as “Ra” — because he'd spent years learning Coptic, the language of Egyptian Christians, which is ancient Egyptian's great-great-grandchild, and in Coptic the sun is “re.” Sound plus picture, mixed together — that was the secret. Hieroglyphs are part alphabet, part emoji. Once he had the key, thousands of years of writing opened at once: love poems, tax records, a schoolboy's teacher writing “your handwriting is terrible” three thousand years ago, and workers' notes complaining about their boss. The first big labor strike in recorded history is Egyptian — tomb builders who stopped work because their bread rations were late. We know because now we can read it.

How to Read a Wall of Hieroglyphs

Here's a secret that turns you into a code-breaker for the rest of the museum. Hieroglyphs look like a zoo of little pictures, owls and snakes and feet and baskets, more than seven hundred different signs. But they aren't a picture story where an owl means owl. Some signs stand for sounds, like our letters, and some are little clues at the end of a word that tell you what kind of thing it is, a squiggle of water after anything wet, a pair of walking legs after anything about moving. Part alphabet, part emoji, all mixed together.

Now here's the trick for reading direction. Find any bird or person in the carving and look at which way its face is turned. You always read toward the faces. If the owls are looking left, you start on the left.

The whole line runs into the faces, like the animals are walking back to the beginning to greet you. Try it on the temple walls upstairs. You'll suddenly know which end is the start, and that alone makes you cleverer than most of the crowd walking past.

And keep hunting for those oval rings, the cartouches, the royal name-tags. Every time you spot one, you've found a king or queen, because only their names got the special loop around them, like drawing a circle of protection.

One more thing, about the stone itself. Almost everybody thinks the Rosetta Stone is black. Look closely. It isn't. It's grey, a speckly grey rock called granodiorite, with a pretty pink vein running across one corner. For about a hundred years people rubbed white chalk into the carved letters to read them, and coated the whole thing in wax to protect it from thousands of touching fingers, and all that gunk turned it dark. Only in 1999 did the museum finally clean it, and the real sparkly grey stone came back. It's heavy too, about the same weight as a small car. And notice the top corners are missing, snapped off long ago. This broken slab was once part of a tall stone taller than a grown-up, standing proudly in a temple.

The Stone's Big Adventure

Think about the journey this broken slab has been on. When the ancient Egyptians finished with it, the stone was forgotten for hundreds of years. People even chopped it up and used it as plain building material, and it ended up buried inside the wall of an old fort near the town of Rosetta. That's where French soldiers found it in 1799, not by digging for treasure, but by knocking into it while building. Imagine being the soldier who realized this lump in the wall was covered in writing.

Here's a clever bit. Before anyone could argue over who owned the stone, scholars did something smart. They smeared ink over the carved surface and pressed paper onto it, like a giant rubbing, and made copies. Those inky copies were sent all around Europe. So the race to crack the code had already started in lots of countries at once, even while the actual stone was being handed from the French to the British. You can't lock up an idea once it's printed.

The stone reached London in the year 1802, and it has barely left since. It became so precious that during the First World War, when the museum was frightened that bombs might fall on London, they hid their greatest treasures deep underground in a tunnel, the Rosetta Stone among them, tucked away in the dark until the danger passed. A national treasure, hiding in a hole.

Today it is the single most looked-at object in the whole museum, always ringed by a crowd holding up phones. But here's something to think about while you stand there. Egypt would like it back. A famous Egyptian archaeologist has asked, more than once, for the stone to come home, because it is Egypt's own history and Egypt's own writing. The British Museum says no, at least for now. What do you think? And one last surprise. That thank-you message to the boy-king wasn't only carved once. It was an official announcement, copied and set up in temples all over Egypt, like putting the same poster up in every town. Other copies have since been found, so even with the corners broken off, we now know exactly what the whole thing said.

Mummies: Recipe for Living Forever

Upstairs are the famous Egyptian mummies, and here's the four-thousand-year-old recipe. Ancient Egyptians believed you needed your body in the afterlife, so they perfected preservation. Step one: remove the squishy organs — but pull the brain out through the nose with a hook, because they thought the brain was useless stuffing. The heart stayed in, because that's where they believed thinking happened. Step two: pack the body in natron, a special salt, for forty days until it's completely dried out. Step three: wrap it in hundreds of meters of linen bandages, tucking in magic amulets between the layers. Total time: seventy days, done properly. Look for the mummy of Katebet, an elderly singer from a temple, and the painted coffins covered in spells — those are instructions and passwords for the afterlife, like a game walkthrough for the world of the dead. And don't miss the Gebelein Man, nicknamed Ginger for his red hair. He's over five thousand years old and wasn't embalmed at all — he was buried in hot sand, which mummified him naturally, skin, hair and all. Scientists CT-scanned him and discovered he was murdered — stabbed in the back. A five-and-a-half-thousand-year-old cold case, solved by a hospital scanner.

Tell Me More: Animal Mummies and Curses

Two more mummy topics. First: Egyptians didn't just mummify people. They mummified cats, dogs, crocodiles, baboons, birds, snakes, and even scarab beetles — millions of animal mummies, mostly as offerings to gods. Cats were sacred to the goddess Bastet, and harming a cat in ancient Egypt could be punished by death. So many cat mummies were made that in the eighteen hundreds, tons of them were shipped to England and — brace yourself — ground up and sold as farm fertilizer. English fields were once fertilized with sacred Egyptian cats. Museum scientists who scan animal mummies sometimes find surprises: some contain just a bone or two, or nothing at all — ancient priests running a souvenir scam, selling “cat mummies” that were mostly bandages. Second: the famous mummy's curse. This museum has a painted coffin lid nicknamed the Unlucky Mummy, blamed by rumor for a century of disasters — some people even claimed it was aboard the Titanic (it wasn't; it never left the museum). Scientists say curses are nonsense, and the tomb of Tutankhamun's “curse” is easily explained: open a sealed tomb and you might breathe ancient mold, and newspapers loved a spooky story. But museum night guards, when asked if the Egyptian rooms feel different after dark, have been known to just smile and change the subject.

The Weighing of the Heart

Remember how the squishy organs got pulled out before wrapping? They didn't just get thrown away. Four of them, the liver, the lungs, the stomach and the intestines, were carefully dried and tucked into four special containers called canopic jars. Look for them in the cases, four little jars standing in a row, each with a different head for a lid. One head is a human, one a baboon, one a jackal, one a falcon. These four were guardian gods, the four sons of the god Horus, and each one had the job of protecting one organ. Ancient Egyptian recycling, with bodyguards.

But one organ never went in a jar. The heart stayed inside the body, right where it belonged, because the heart had the most important job of all, and it was coming to the biggest test in the whole afterlife.

Here is what the Egyptians believed happened after you died. You travel through the underworld and arrive at an enormous set of scales. On one side, they place your heart. On the other side, a single feather, the feather of truth. Then everyone watches to see which way the scales tip. If your heart is light, as light as that feather, because you lived a good and honest life, you pass the test and go on to paradise. But if your heart is heavy, weighed down with lies and cruelty and all the bad things you did, the scales sink, and that is very bad news. Because crouching right there beside the scales waits a monster named Ammit.

Ammit is part crocodile, with those snapping jaws, part lion, and part hippopotamus, and if your heart is too heavy, Ammit gobbles it up, and you are gone forever.

So people were nervous. What if your own heart blabbed about the naughty things you'd done? To be safe, they slipped a special good-luck charm shaped like a scarab beetle right over the heart, wrapped into the bandages, and carved on it was a little spell. And the spell was basically a polite message to your own heart, begging it, please, whatever you do, don't tell on me at the weighing. Imagine having to bribe your own heart to keep quiet.

Mummy Detectives and Mummy Paint

Nobody unwraps mummies any more. It would destroy them, and honestly it isn't very kind. So how do scientists find out what's inside? They borrow the exact same machine a hospital uses on you if you break your arm, a CT scanner, and they roll the whole wrapped mummy through it. In seconds they can see straight through the bandages without touching a thing, like giving a four-thousand-year-old person an X-ray.

And what they find is amazing. Hidden lucky charms tucked between the layers. Little fake eyes placed under the eyelids so the person could see in the afterlife. Padding stuffed into the cheeks to make a shrivelled face look plump and alive again. And here's a surprising one. Lots of mummies have terrible teeth, worn right down and flat. Why? Because ancient Egyptian bread was full of grit and tiny bits of sand that blew in from the desert while it was being made. Every bite was like chewing on sandpaper, slowly grinding their teeth away. Four thousand years later, the scanner can still see the toothache.

Now, brace yourself, because here comes the properly gross part, and it isn't about the ancient Egyptians at all. It's about people much closer to us in time. About a hundred and fifty years ago, rich people in London thought mummies were wildly exciting, and they did some truly weird things with them. One doctor, nicknamed Mummy Pettigrew, used to unwrap real ancient mummies on a stage in front of huge crowds, sometimes thousands of people, as an evening's entertainment. Imagine buying a ticket to watch that.

It gets worse. Ground-up mummies were turned into a brownish paint, and it had a name, mummy brown, and famous artists actually squeezed it onto their brushes and painted pictures with it. Somewhere out there hang paintings coloured with real ancient Egyptians. And, yuck of all yucks, for hundreds of years people even swallowed powdered mummy as medicine, believing it could cure them. So the next time someone says history is boring, tell them about the doctors who unwrapped mummies for a party, the painters who painted with them, and the patients who ate them. Boring is not the word.

Servants, Games, and a Perfect Farm

Here's a problem the ancient Egyptians worried about. The afterlife sounded lovely, a paradise, but paradise still had fields to plough and ditches to dig, and nobody, not even a dead person, wanted to do chores forever. So they came up with a brilliant cheat. They packed the tomb with tiny servant dolls.

Look for them in the cases, little mummy-shaped figures the size of your hand, often bright blue-green. They're called shabti, and the word means something like the answerer. The idea was magical. Whenever the gods called out in the afterlife, hey, we need someone to go work in the fields, your little shabti would answer for you and do the job, so you could put your feet up. And people didn't just pack one or two. A wealthy Egyptian could be buried with more than four hundred shabti, three hundred and sixty-five of them, one worker for every single day of the year, plus another thirty-six little bosses called overseers, whose whole job was to keep the workers in line. An entire tiny workforce, packed in a box, ready for eternity.

You also took the things you loved most in life. And one of the most popular was a board game called Senet. It was played on a board of thirty squares, three rows of ten, and instead of dice they threw little sticks to see how far to move. But Senet wasn't just a game to pass the time. Egyptians came to believe that when you played it in the tomb, you were really playing against an invisible opponent, moving your pieces through danger toward the afterlife itself. A board game where the prize was your soul.

And what were you playing your way toward? The reward was called the Field of Reeds. Here's the surprising thing about the ancient Egyptian idea of heaven. It wasn't clouds and floating around. It was, basically, Egypt, but perfect. A beautiful river, exactly like their beloved Nile. Rich black earth for farming. Blue skies, good food, your family around you, and best of all, harvests that never, ever failed. Their idea of paradise was simply their own home country on its very best day, going on forever. And now you know why they packed the servants. Even in paradise, somebody had to bring in the harvest, and it certainly wasn't going to be them.

Treasure Hunt: A Ghost Ship and a Chess Army

Two more treasures if you have the energy. First, the Sutton Hoo helmet — the face of a ghost king. In 1939, a landowner in Suffolk asked an archaeologist to dig into the big mounds on her property. Inside the largest one they found the shape of an entire twenty-seven-meter Viking-style ship — the wood had rotted away completely, leaving only a perfect ship-shaped shadow in the sand, with every iron rivet still in place. At its center: the treasure of an Anglo-Saxon king from around the year 625, probably King Raedwald. The helmet, with its eyebrows, mustache and mask, is one of the most famous faces in Britain — look closely and you'll see the eyebrows, nose and mustache together form a dragon or a bird flying upward. Second, the Lewis Chessmen: a small army of chess pieces carved from walrus tusk in the 1100s, found buried in a sand dune on a Scottish island. Nobody knows who hid them or why they never came back. The best part is their faces: the queens slump their cheek on one hand looking utterly fed up, and some of the warriors are “berserkers” — biting the tops of their shields in battle fury. If they look familiar: a Lewis chessman played a role in Harry Potter's wizard chess.

Tell Me More: The Dig of 1939 and the Chess Hoard

The Sutton Hoo dig has a movie-worthy backstory (there IS a movie — *The Dig*). Edith Pretty, the landowner, had traveled the world and always wondered about the strange mounds on her lawn; some say a friend claimed to see ghostly warriors standing on them. She hired Basil Brown, a local man who'd left school at twelve but taught himself archaeology, astronomy, and several languages. He excavated with a coal shovel, pastry brushes and bellows — and when he found the first ship rivet, he knew instantly what he had. Then the big-university archaeologists arrived and pushed him aside; Basil kept working anyway, quietly, and today the museum credits him properly. The treasure went to Edith Pretty by law — a jury decided it was hers — and she gave ALL of it to the museum, then turned down the honor of becoming a Dame. Weeks later, World War Two began, and the priceless finds spent the war hidden in a London Underground tunnel. As for the Lewis Chessmen: seventy-eight pieces came from that Scottish beach, plus buttons and other bits — likely five chess sets' worth, minus a few pieces that had wandered off. Keep your eyes open in Edinburgh next week: eleven of the chessmen live at the museum there, so by the end of your trip you'll have visited both halves of the same buried treasure.

Giant Winged Monsters and a Stone Comic Strip

Leave Egypt for a moment and go hunting for monsters. Down among the ancient Assyrian rooms, guarding old doorways, stand two of the most enormous creatures in the whole museum. They're taller than the ceiling of most houses, carved from single blocks of stone, and they are seriously strange. Each one has the body of a lion or a bull, two great eagle wings folded on its back, and, on top, a calm human face with a long curly beard and a fancy hat. They're called lamassu, and they were magical guardians. Kings put them at their palace gates to scare away enemies and evil spirits. If you were a visitor three thousand years ago, walking up to the king, these were the last thing you saw before you lost your nerve.

Now here's the puzzle. Walk up to one and count its legs. Go on, count. You'll get five. Five legs! Is that a mistake? Not at all, it's a clever trick. Look at the lamassu straight from the front, and you see two front legs planted firmly, standing still and solid, like a guard at attention. But walk to the side and look again, and now you see four legs striding forward, marching, alive. The sculptor gave it an extra leg so that it looks perfect from both directions, standing when you meet it, walking when you pass it. A statue that seems to come to life as you move.

Right nearby is something like the world's oldest comic strip, a long wall of carvings that tells a story panel

by panel. It shows a mighty Assyrian king named Ashurbanipal hunting lions, and it is breathtakingly detailed, made about two thousand six hundred years ago. You can follow the whole action, the lions leaping from cages, the king in his chariot, the arrows flying. But here's the twist that surprises everybody. The artist carved the lions so beautifully, with such feeling, some of them wounded, roaring, struggling, that most people who stand in front of it today don't cheer for the king at all. They feel sorry for the lions. The hunter wanted you to admire him. Instead, almost three thousand years later, our hearts go to the animals. Not many artists get remembered for the opposite of what they meant.

A Stone Giant and a Skull That Fooled Everyone

Three more treasures for your hunt, from three completely different corners of the world.

First, find the stone giant. Standing among the crowds is a huge carved figure from Easter Island, one of the loneliest places on the entire planet, a tiny speck of land thousands of miles out in the Pacific Ocean, so far from anywhere it's a wonder anyone ever found it. His name is roughly Hoa Hakananai'a, and he was carved perhaps eight hundred years ago by the island's people, who made hundreds of these giants and stood them up facing their villages. A British navy ship took this one away in 1868, and carried him halfway around the world to London. The people of Easter Island have said, quite plainly, that they would like their ancestor to come home. Stand in front of him and see what you think.

Second, hunt for a snake with a problem, it has two heads and no tail. It's a serpent, a bit longer than your arm, and its whole body is covered in thousands of tiny sky-blue stones called turquoise, fitted together like the world's most patient jigsaw. It was made in Mexico, by brilliant craftsmen, for the Aztecs, and it may have been worn on the chest of a priest during ceremonies. Up close, you can see every single little stone was placed by hand.

And third, the trickster of the museum, a skull. Not a real bone skull, but a life-size human skull carved from a single lump of clear, glassy crystal. For a long time everyone was sure it was a mysterious ancient Aztec treasure, and people whispered that crystal skulls had magic powers. But then scientists put it under a super-powerful microscope and looked very, very closely at the surface. And there, around the eye sockets and teeth, they spotted the truth, tiny regular scratch marks left by a spinning cutting wheel. The catch? The Aztecs never had spinning wheels like that. This skull was a fake, carved not thousands of years ago but only in the eighteen hundreds, probably in Germany, and sold to fool collectors. And fool them it did, for about a hundred years, until a microscope finally cracked the case.